Lecture Notes, Week 8: Politics Without Romance

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Monday, October 5 and Wednesday, October 7, 2026

What these notes cover: the two Week 8 lectures, in both sections; there was no class on Friday, October 9 (Homecoming). They open the politics part of the course by applying the economist's model of the person to politics. On Monday, the romantic view of the state: the people who govern and the people who vote are the same people we meet in markets, and "the will of the people" may not exist to be carried out, because with three or more options majority voting can go in a circle and whoever sets the agenda picks the winner. On Wednesday, the voters themselves: one vote almost never decides an election, so on a narrow count of costs and benefits almost nobody should vote or learn about politics. People vote anyway, out of duty, under social pressure, and to express who they are, and they stay rationally ignorant of most of what they vote on.

Readings: Required: Buchanan, "Public Choice: Politics Without Romance" (2003). Optional: Rousseau, *The Social Contract* (1762), selections on the general will; *Cato's Letters* Nos. 33 and 60–64; Feddersen, "Rational Choice Theory and the Paradox of Not Voting" (2004). All are in the Week 8 folder of the class repository. Page numbers for Buchanan are those of the class copy. **Quiz 7 and AI Dialogue 2 are both due Friday, October 16.**

Lecture	Topic	Sections
Monday, October 5	Politics without romance; does the general will exist?	1–14
Wednesday, October 7	Why vote, and what do voters know?	15–26

Monday, October 5: Politics without romance; does the general will exist?

The romantic view treats the state as a benevolent being that carries out the will of the people. Monday took that view apart twice. First, the people who run the state, and the people who vote, are the same people we meet in markets, with the same motives. Second, "the will of the people" may not exist to be carried out: with three or more options, counting votes can go in a circle, and whoever sets the order of the votes picks the winner.

1. Politics with romance

- People tend to be cynical about the politicians on the other side and romantic about those on their own. The romantic view of the state goes further: "the government" becomes a wise and benevolent being, like the unicorn on the first slide, that nobody has ever met.
- Some romance in politics is useful. Americans are romantic about their Constitution, and that shared attachment helps people agree on how the political process should work. Buchanan (p. 4): "in a constitutional democracy, persons owe loyalty to the constitution rather than to the government." Thinking about politics only in romantic terms, however, leads to bad policy.

2. The government vs. the politicians you know

- The question put to the class: should the government fight disinformation online? Both sections gave reasonable answers on both sides: free speech, the difficulty of defining disinformation, harm to others, warnings rather than bans.
- Now replace "the government" with the politician you trust least. "The government" is an impersonal noun, but somebody has to decide what counts as disinformation and enforce the decision. Would you still give that power to the person you most disagree with? That person probably thinks you are the one spreading disinformation.
- The test: would I support this policy if my worst political opponent were in charge of carrying it out? Sometimes the answer is still yes; nobody proposes to dismantle the army because the other party will one day command it. When the answer changes, you were reasoning as if your own side would hold power forever. In a democracy, majorities rotate.

3. Public choice

- **Public choice** applies the tools of economics to politics. People often analyze a CEO in cynical terms: he is after money and does not care about others. If the same CEO becomes a senator, half the country decides he is evil and the other half acts as if he received a soul transplant. Politicians are not "just like us" the way a gorilla is almost like us. They *are* us: the same kind of people, with the same motives, though politics may select people with particular traits.

- The same goes for voters. People who say their neighbors are too foolish to shop wisely at the grocery store should not assume that those same neighbors become experts on foreign policy in the voting booth. The shopper and the voter are the same person facing different incentives, and the incentive to get informed differs between the two settings (Wednesday's topic). This idea is usually called **behavioral symmetry**: one model of the person, in markets and in politics.
- Buchanan (p. 5): "Public choice, as an inclusive research programme, incorporates the presumption that persons do not readily become economic eunuchs as they shift from market to political participation. Those who respond predictably to ordinary incentives in the marketplace do not fail to respond at all when they act as citizens."
- His target was the welfare economics of the 1930s and 1940s, which listed the ways real markets fall short of an ideal (monopoly, pollution, fraud, public goods) and assumed that government would fix each failure perfectly: "market failures were set against an idealized politics" (p. 4). Public choice supplies theories of government failure to set beside the theories of market failure. Buchanan summed it up in the title of a 1978 lecture in Vienna: "politics without romance."
- Behavioral symmetry does not deny that some people go into politics to do good. Buchanan grants that people in political roles "may, indeed, act to a degree in terms of what they consider to be the general interest" (p. 5). The claim is that incentives still matter.
- Example (11:45 section). Economists can make a case for government deficits in some circumstances. Hand that argument to a politician and he may overuse it, because borrowing lets him spend on voters now and leave the bill for later. Governments tend to raise spending and transfers before elections, a **political budget cycle**; the pattern is strongest in new democracies (Brender and Drazen, 2005).

4. The Founders without romance

- Madison, *The Federalist* No. 51 (1788): "If men were angels, no government would be necessary. If angels were to govern men, neither external nor internal controls on government would be necessary. In framing a government which is to be administered by men over men, the great difficulty lies in this: you must first enable the government to control the governed; and in the next place oblige it to control itself." His method, one sentence earlier: "Ambition must be made to counteract ambition."
- Buchanan himself says public choice adds little to the Founders: it "incorporates an understanding of human nature that differs little, if at all, from that of James Madison and his colleagues" (p. 6).
- People are not angels, so a constitution needs checks and balances, and limits on what a majority may do to a minority.
- Asked in the 11:45 section: should every generation rewrite its constitution? Jefferson wrote to Madison in September 1789 that "the earth belongs … to the living" and that every constitution and every law should expire after 19 years, his estimate of a generation. Madison disagreed. He had already warned, in *Federalist* No. 49 (1788), that frequent appeals to the people "would, in a great measure, deprive the government of that veneration which time bestows on every thing, and without which perhaps the wisest and freest governments would not possess the requisite stability."
- Asked in the 11:45 section: how hard is the U.S. Constitution to amend? Under Article V, an amendment is proposed by two-thirds of both houses of Congress (or by a convention called at the request of two-thirds of the states) and ratified by three-fourths of the states. The president plays no part. Ordinary legislation also needs more than a bare majority in practice: the Senate filibuster means that most bills need 60 votes to come to a vote.
- Asked in the 11:45 section: are political parties a good thing? Washington's Farewell Address (1796) warned against "the spirit of party." One economic view of parties is that they act as middlemen for voters, who know little about each candidate. A party label works like a brand: you know roughly what you get at a McDonald's in Paris or in Gainesville without studying the menu. Whether two is the right number of parties is a separate question.

5. The general will

- The slide shows the *Landsgemeinde* of the canton of Glarus, Switzerland. On the first Sunday in May the citizens meet in the open air and vote on laws, officials, and the tax rate by raising their voting cards. Only Glarus and Appenzell Innerrhoden still hold one. Rousseau, a citizen of Geneva, admired such assemblies, though he names no country: "bands of peasants are seen regulating affairs of State under an oak, and always acting wisely" (*Social Contract*, IV.1).
- The **general will** is what the people as a whole want for their common good, as distinct from what each person wants for himself (Rousseau, *The Social Contract*, 1762). Rousseau contrasts it with the "will of all," which "is no more than a sum of particular wills" (II.3). Related terms: the common good, the public interest, the general welfare, the will of the people.

- How is the general will found? Rousseau (IV.2): "[W]hat the people is asked is not exactly whether it approves or rejects the proposal, but whether it is in conformity with the general will, which is their will. Each man, in giving his vote, states his opinion on that point; and the general will is found by counting votes. When therefore the opinion that is contrary to my own prevails, this proves neither more nor less than that I was mistaken, and that what I thought to be the general will was not so."
- Rousseau thought democracy works best in small, simple, homogeneous communities, and even then doubted it suited human beings: "Were there a people of gods, their government would be democratic. So perfect a government is not for men" (III.4).
- Who could be against the will of the people? The answer given in class: voting and representative institutions work fairly well, but not because they carry out the will of the people. There are two problems with that justification:
  - Implementation. Even if the will of the people existed, a country cannot vote on everything in one square, so it must delegate, and delegates can depart from what voters want. (Asked in class: should representatives follow their voters' wishes, as delegates, or their own judgment, as trustees? The distinction goes back to Edmund Burke's *Speech to the Electors of Bristol*, 1774.)
  - Existence. "The people" is a collection of individuals with different and often conflicting interests. It is not clear that their wishes add up to one will (Sections 9 and 13 below).
- Do votes reveal what people want for the common good? In a store you often discover what you want as you shop: you see a bag of cookies, check the price, and decide. It is your money and your cookies, so you have every reason to choose well. In the voting booth the costs and benefits of your choice are spread across everyone, and your vote almost never decides the outcome, so the incentive to work out what you want is much weaker. Nor is it clear that voters vote on the common good rather than on their own interest. Voters do vote their pocketbooks when the stakes are large and personal, as homeowners do on property taxes, though much of the evidence finds that they vote on what they believe is good for the country (Week 10 returns to this).

6. Robespierre and the general will

- Maximilien Robespierre (1758–1794), a leader of the Jacobins in the French Revolution and an admirer of Rousseau, speaking on the constitution, 10 May 1793: "Government is established to make the general will respected; but men who govern have individual wills, and every will seeks to dominate." That is behavioral symmetry applied to rulers.
- He applied it only to rulers. Two pages later in the same speech he lays down the maxim that "the people is good, and its delegates are corruptible." He suspected the governors and trusted the people. Behavioral symmetry goes further: every will seeks to dominate, the voters' included.
- Robespierre knew that much of France, especially in the provinces, did not support the Jacobins. His answer was that the people had been misled, by aristocrats, royalists, and priests, so the general will and the will of the majority were two different things. Rousseau had supplied the argument: "the people is never corrupted, but it is often deceived" (II.3). "How convenient": once the general will can differ from what the majority votes, whoever claims to know it can override the majority.
- If the people is the embodiment of virtue, anything that constrains it looks like an obstacle to virtue, and a republic needs no separation of powers. The National Convention of 1792–1795 sat as a single chamber and held nearly all authority: it ran the executive through its own committees and tried the king itself.

7. One center or many bodies?

- The slide sets the Convention's single hall in Paris (1792) beside the U.S. Capitol, with two chambers, a president, and a court. Which one carries out the general will?
- Anne-Robert-Jacques Turgot (1727–1781), economist and Louis XVI's Controller General of Finances (finance minister) from 1774 to 1776. In economics he reasoned in trade-offs; he argued, for instance, that the *corvée*, unpaid forced labor on the roads, produced bad roads, and he replaced it with a tax. In politics he reasoned like a philosopher-king. Letter to Richard Price (1778) on the new American state constitutions: "Instead of collecting all authority into one center, that of the nation, they have established different bodies; a body of representatives, a council, and a Governour, because there is in England a House of Commons, a House of Lords, and a King.—They endeavour to balance these different powers, as if this equilibrium, which in England may be a necessary check to the enormous influence of royalty, could be of any use in Republics founded upon the equality of all the Citizens [. . .]"
- Turgot's point: checks and balances make sense against a king, but in a republic of equal citizens they only obstruct the nation's will. John Adams answered him in *A Defence of the Constitutions of Government of the United States of America* (1787–88).

– Asked in class: why do checks and balances help? Students answered that they make officials more careful, because a mistake or abuse can be undone, and that they let a government experiment, because a bad policy can be reversed or vetoed.

8. The general welfare

– Preamble of the Constitution (1787): "We the People of the United States, in Order to form a more perfect Union, establish Justice, insure domestic Tranquility, provide for the common defence, promote the general Welfare, and secure the Blessings of Liberty to ourselves and our Posterity, do ordain and establish this Constitution for the United States of America."
– "The will of the people" does not appear. The general welfare is one goal in a list, not the first, and it stands at the head of a document built to restrain whoever claims to pursue it: three branches and two chambers, the "different bodies" Turgot deplored. Note also "a *more* perfect Union," not a perfect one.

9. Condorcet's paradox

	1st	2nd	3rd
Voter 1	A	B	C
Voter 2	B	C	A
Voter 3	C	A	B

– Which option does the group want? Hold a majority vote on each pair:
  ◦ A beats B, 2 to 1 (voters 1 and 3).
  ◦ B beats C, 2 to 1 (voters 1 and 2).
  ◦ C beats A, 2 to 1 (voters 2 and 3).
– No option beats both others. Each voter's ranking is consistent, but **the majority's ranking goes in a circle**: a **majority cycle**. The ranking is not transitive.
– A person with these preferences would be irrational, and you could take all his money (11:45 section). He prefers A to B, so he pays a little to swap his B for an A. He prefers C to A, so he pays again to swap A for C, and again to swap C for B. He ends up holding B, poorer than when he started, and the trades can go on forever. A group can have such a ranking even though none of its members does.
– Nicolas de Condorcet (1743–1794), mathematician and a deputy in the Revolutionary assemblies, described the paradox in 1785. He died in prison in March 1794. The paradox was largely forgotten until Duncan Black rediscovered it in 1948.
– Two options are easy: a majority picks one. Real politics rarely offers only two, and every added option or dimension multiplies the chances of a cycle.

10. Who sets the agenda?

– The **agenda** is the order of the votes. Two options meet first; the winner then meets the option held back. With the voters above:
  ◦ A vs. B first ⇒ A. Then A vs. C ⇒ C wins.
  ◦ B vs. C first ⇒ B. Then B vs. A ⇒ A wins.
  ◦ A vs. C first ⇒ C. Then C vs. B ⇒ B wins.
– The option held back wins every time, so whoever sets the agenda picks the winner, although nobody changed a vote. The same holds more simply if the agenda setter only chooses which pair goes to a single referendum: to get A, put up A against B; to get B, B against C; to get C, C against A.
– Much of politics is a fight over the agenda. Parties, interest groups, and candidates each try to put in front of voters the issues that favor them: one side may campaign on immigration, the other on health care.

11. Buchanan's reply: cycles protect minorities

– Kenneth Arrow and Duncan Black concluded that majority rule could not promote any general interest and that majoritarian democracy was unstable. Buchanan turned the result around (p. 1): "Aren't 'majority cycles' the most desirable outcome of a democratic process? After all, any attainment of political equilibrium via majority rule would amount to the permanent imposition of the majority's will on the outvoted minority."
– With the voters above, voters 1 and 2 cannot gang up on voter 3 for good, because on another question voters 1 and 3, or 2 and 3, form the majority. When majorities rotate, today's loser can win tomorrow.
– The cycle is a problem only if democracy's job is to find the will of the people. If its job is to keep any one group

from exploiting the others, the cycle helps.

– Majority rule has limits that most people accept. If everyone in this class but one voted to expropriate the remaining student, few would call the result legitimate because a majority approved it. Buchanan follows the Swedish economist Knut Wicksell (1896) in judging collective decisions against unanimity, and in favoring rules that require more than a bare majority (pp. 1–2). Week 9 takes up constitutional choice.

12. Did the Founders know Condorcet?

– They knew the man and owned his books. Jefferson lived in Paris from 1784 and was U.S. minister to France from 1785 to 1789, where he was a close friend of Condorcet. Jefferson sent Madison books by Condorcet; in 1788 Madison forwarded the 1785 *Essai* to Edmund Randolph.

– McLean and Urken (1992) find no sign that Jefferson or Madison understood Condorcet's theory of social choice. Madison's constitution did not rest on a general will in the first place.

13. Arrow's impossibility theorem

– Rousseau: the general will "is found by counting votes." Count our three voters, and whichever option is chosen, a majority prefers another.

– Is the problem majority rule? Perhaps a better rule exists: a 60 percent threshold, weighting some voters more, ranking the options and adding up points. Kenneth Arrow (1951) proved that, with three or more options, no voting rule can turn every set of rankings into a cycle-free group ranking and meet a few mild conditions, unless one voter always prevails. A voting rule should:
  - work whatever rankings the voters happen to have;
  - rank A above B whenever every voter does (unanimity);
  - decide A vs. B only from how voters rank A against B, whatever they think of C (**independence of irrelevant alternatives**);
  - give no single voter the last word (no dictator). A dictator escapes the problem: the group's ranking is then simply his.

– An example of the third condition. In Florida in 2000, Ralph Nader's candidacy may have decided the contest between George W. Bush and Al Gore, although no voter changed how he ranked Bush against Gore. Plurality voting fails the condition: whether Bush or Gore wins can depend on whether Nader is on the ballot.

– What the theorem does not say: that groups always cycle. It says that every rule meeting the conditions will fail for some set of rankings, so no voting rule is guaranteed to find a coherent will of the people. Week 10 looks at a case in which majority voting does not cycle.

– Arrow proved the theorem as a graduate student and shared the 1972 Nobel Prize in economics with John Hicks.

– The theorem assumes that every voter has a clear ranking. Even that is doubtful: like shoppers who discover what they want in the aisle, voters may form their preferences during the political process itself.

14. What follows

– Counting votes does not find the general will. The voting rule and the agenda make one.

– This is not an argument against voting. Voting may be the best way we have to settle disputes peacefully: people have conflicting interests, and rules that sometimes produce poor policy are still better than fighting, or the state of nature. What fails is the justification of voting as a way of discovering "the will of the people." The romantic fiction may still be useful, but it is a fiction.

– "Democracy" is itself a slippery word, often used to mean "the institutions I like." If it means pure majority rule, few countries qualify. In the French parliamentary election of 2017, the president's party and its ally won about a third of the first-round vote, on a turnout below one half, and took 350 of the 577 seats (12:50 section).

– Wednesday: the voters themselves. Why do people vote, given that one vote almost never decides an election? And how much do they know when they do?

Wednesday, October 7: Why vote, and what do voters know?

Monday applied behavioral symmetry to rulers; Wednesday applied it to voters. One vote almost never decides an election, so on a narrow count of costs and benefits almost nobody should vote, and nobody should spend much time learning about politics. Yet about 64 percent of eligible Americans voted in 2024. People vote out of duty, under social pressure, and to express who they are, and they stay rationally ignorant of most of what they vote on.

15. What do voters know?

- Each section opened with a quiz: name the Secretaries of State, the Treasury, the Interior, and Labor, your representative, and Florida's two senators; then guess the size of the federal budget. Both rooms knew the Secretary of State and the senators; almost nobody knew the Secretaries of the Interior or Labor. Guesses for the budget ran from $4 billion to hundreds of trillions of dollars. Federal spending in fiscal year 2025 was about $7 trillion (CBO).
- Nobody guesses $400 for a gallon of gasoline. We buy gasoline every week, and a wrong guess costs us money. Nothing disciplines our guesses about the federal budget.
- Joseph Schumpeter (1883–1950), an Austrian economist and briefly his country's finance minister, *Capitalism, Socialism and Democracy* (1942, p. 262): "[T]he typical citizen drops down to a lower level of mental performance as soon as he enters the political field. He argues and analyzes in a way which he would readily recognize as infantile within the sphere of his real interests. He becomes a primitive again."
- H. L. Mencken (1880–1956), Baltimore journalist, *A Little Book in C Major* (1916): "Democracy is the theory that the common people know what they want, and deserve to get it good and hard."
- The question for the day: are voters stupid, or are they responding to incentives? The economist's answer is the second. Knowing little about politics is a rational choice.

16. Why vote?

- Why do people wait in line, sometimes for hours, to vote? Answers in class: to have their voice heard, because it is their right, out of pride, out of civic duty, because the Constitution works only if people take part, and because they do not trust others to choose well.
- A right explains why you may vote, not why you do. As one student put it, "it's my right to own a gun, and I don't own a gun."
- To make a difference? Your vote changes the outcome in one case only: when the other votes are tied. An election won by 10 or 16 votes is close, but no single vote decided it. Take any one ballot away and the same candidate wins.
- "What if everyone thought like that?" If nobody else voted, your vote would decide, and you should vote. But others do vote. That voting is good for the group if many people do it (**collective rationality**) does not make it worth the trouble for any one person (**individual rationality**).

17. The calculus of voting

- Anthony Downs, *An Economic Theory of Democracy* (1957): vote if the benefit you expect from voting beats its cost, $p \times B > C$.
  - p: the chance that your vote decides the election.
  - B: what your side's win is worth to you.
  - C: the cost of voting: time, gas, whatever else you could have done.
- A vote works like a lottery ticket, worth the prize times the chance of winning it. B can be large: the winner sets taxes, picks judges, and may send soldiers abroad. The problem is p.

18. How small is the chance of a decisive vote?

- U.S. House races, 1898–1992: one in 16,577 was decided by a single vote (New York's 36th district in 1910, 20,685 to 20,684; Mulligan and Hunter, 2003).
- The 2008 presidential election: a week before the vote, the average voter's chance of deciding it was about 1 in 60 million (Gelman, Silver, and Edlin, 2012). Twenty-six heads in a row is about as likely (1 in 67 million); the Powerball jackpot is less likely (1 in 292 million).
- Florida, 2000: Bush won by 537 votes out of about 6 million. Even there no single vote decided the election. Recounts, lawyers, and finally the Supreme Court (*Bush v. Gore*) did.
- The chance falls fast as a race moves away from a tie. In 2008 it was about 1 in 10 million in the closest states (New Mexico, Virginia, New Hampshire, Colorado) and about 1 in 5 billion in Utah. The same goes for House seats: a vote in a district that goes 80 percent to one party is worth far less than a vote in a swing district.

– On the graph shown in class, the chance peaks a little to the right of 50 percent. That is the Electoral College: a vote counts only if it swings its state and the state swings the national result. Obama was expected to win in 2008, so the states that would decide a closer race were those he was expected to carry narrowly.
– **The paradox of voting.** For almost everyone, $p \times B$ is far smaller than C, so on this arithmetic almost nobody should vote. Yet about 64 percent of eligible Americans voted in 2024 (UF Election Lab). Either voters are irrational, or the arithmetic leaves something out. The rest of the lecture took the second view.

19. The altruistic voter

– If you care about everyone the election affects, B is the stakes for hundreds of millions of people, and $p \times B$ can beat C (Edlin, Gelman, and Kaplan, 2007). Gelman, Silver, and Edlin (2012, p. 324): "[A] vote is like a lottery ticket with a 1 in 10 million chance of winning, but the payoff is the chance to change national policy and improve (one hopes) the lives of hundreds of millions [. . .]"
– The objection raised in class: this assumes that people become hyper-altruistic in the voting booth, caring about the whole country rather than about themselves and those close to them. Behavioral symmetry says to doubt it.
– A student's reply (11:45 section): altruism is cheap in the booth. Because your vote almost never decides, voting for the national interest instead of your own costs you nothing.
– The reply cuts both ways. If altruism is cheap, so are ignorance, anger, and crazy or evil options. This is Brennan and Buchanan's (1984) hypothesis of the **irresponsible voter**: you can vote for what feels good rather than for what you would choose if you had to live with the result. The **noble voter** is the same logic run the other way: the low cost frees you to vote your ideals. Which one wins is an open question; Week 10 (Caplan) returns to it.

20. Civic duty

– Riker and Ordeshook (1968) add a reward for the act of voting itself: $p \times B + D > C$. D is the satisfaction of doing your duty, for the same reason you hold the door for a stranger. D does not depend on who wins, so anyone whose D exceeds C votes even when p is close to zero.
– The evidence fits: in 1952–60, 87 percent of citizens with a high sense of duty said they voted, against 51 percent of those with a low one.
– The danger is circularity. Why do people vote? Because the benefit exceeds the cost. How do we know? Because they vote. Add a term for every fact and the theory fits any turnout and predicts none.
– Voting out of duty is perfectly reasonable. Voting in order to change the outcome is not: there, your means do not fit your end.
– Duty can be talked away. During Canada's 1993 election, a ten-minute presentation on the paradox of voting cut university students' turnout by 7 percentage points, mainly by weakening their sense of duty (Blais and Young, 1999). The point of this lecture is not that you should stop voting.

21. Social pressure

– Michigan, August 2006 primary: households received one of several letters, or none (Gerber, Green, and Larimer, 2008).

Letter	Turnout
No letter	29.7%
Civic duty: a reminder that voting is your duty	31.5%
Neighbors: your neighbors will see whether you voted	37.8%

– Being seen raised turnout more than four times as much as being reminded of your duty. People also vote so that they can tell others they did (DellaVigna, List, Malmendier, and Rao, 2017). Social pressure is part of D, and it works on most people.

22. Expressive voting

– Who says "we won" after a Gators game? The Swamp holds 88,548 people, and none of their cheers changes the score. Fans go because they enjoy it.
– **Expressive voting**: voting to show who you are and whom you back, not to change who wins. Brennan and Lomasky (*Democracy and Decision*, 1993, p. 33) on the sports fan: "But even the most enthusiastic partisan does not and cannot believe that his cheering brings about the outcome for which his cheering is expressed."
– Politics as a team sport: the cable news channel that gets you riled up, the election-night party, the rally, the "I voted" sticker. None of this is bad. Without such private rewards few people would vote, and democracy would be

hard to keep going.

– Celebrity endorsements work through D, not p. A ballot is secret; a post about it has an audience. On September 10, 2024, Taylor Swift's endorsement of Kamala Harris sent 405,999 visitors to the federal site vote.gov within 24 hours. Politicians seek endorsements, concerts, and music because they work; competition would weed out those who wasted money on them.

23. A test: third parties

– A purely expressive voter backs her favorite even when it cannot win. Many Americans are closer to the Libertarian or Green Party than to either major party, yet vote Republican or Democrat so as not to "waste" their vote, as if their vote might count. The two-party system is itself an outcome to be explained, not a fact of nature: plurality voting in single-member districts tends to produce two parties (**Duverger's law**).

– Evidence against pure expressive voting: in Germany, about a third of voters whose favorite cannot win switch to one who can (Spenkuch, 2013), a form of **strategic voting**. When a published poll showed a Swiss referendum was close, more people voted right away (Bursztyn et al., 2024).

– Evidence for it: the other two-thirds stay with their favorite. In U.S. field experiments, telling voters the race will be close barely moves turnout (Gerber et al., 2020). In Florida in 2000, 97,488 people voted for Ralph Nader in a state decided by 537 votes.

– A richer version of expressive voting fits better: people like to back a winner. And voting for a favorite costs least where the outcome is not in doubt, as for a Libertarian in Oklahoma or a Green in California.

– Asked in the 11:45 section: did Nader's voters decide the 2000 election? As a group, they could have: had 538 of the 97,488 voted for Gore instead, he would have carried Florida. As individuals, no: no single Nader vote changed the result.

24. Rational ignorance

– **Rational ignorance**: choosing not to learn about politics, because learning costs more than your one vote can pay back. Downs (1957, p. 259): "In general, it is irrational to be politically well-informed because the low returns from data simply do not justify their cost in time and other scarce resources."

– A voter who spends a month learning how the federal budget works (even experts see only part of it) improves policy only if his vote decides, which it almost never does. At the store, by contrast, your choice is decisive: you may spend weeks researching a $1,000 phone and minutes on a candidate who will manage billions in taxes.

– What voters know: in 2010, 59 percent of Americans could name the vice president (Pew). In 2026, 65 percent could name the three branches of government (Annenberg). In 2025, the average guess for foreign aid's share of the federal budget was 26 percent; the actual share is about 1 percent (KFF). Before feeling superior, guess Social Security's share of federal spending, then look it up.

– Parties as brands (12:50 section). A rationally ignorant voter cannot research every candidate. A party label tells him roughly what he will get, as the McDonald's or Marriott name does: "I don't even know the guy's name, but I'm voting Democrat" (or Republican). Whether the information is accurate is another matter.

25. Does voter ignorance matter?

– Perhaps not. If uninformed voters err at random, their errors split between the candidates and cancel, and the informed voters decide the outcome: a wisdom of the crowd, sometimes called the **miracle of aggregation**. Week 10's reading (Caplan) asks whether voters' errors are random or systematic.

– Voters who know little are easy to sway with new information. That can be good or bad: those who care most about a policy spend the most to persuade voters, which may produce better policy or may not (12:50 section).

26. Politics without romance: the week in four ideas

– **Behavioral symmetry**: one model of the person in markets and in politics. Monday applied it to rulers, Wednesday to voters.

– **Majority cycles**: counting votes can go in a circle, so it need not find a general will, and whoever sets the agenda picks the winner.

– **Rational ignorance**: one vote almost never decides, so learning about politics does not pay.

– **Expressive voting**: people vote, and vote as they do, partly for what the vote says about them.